



Photo: NRC/Tiril Skarstein

Maneno feeding her little niece Asante in Bidibidi settlement. The family fled from Yei in South Sudan to Uganda. Bidibidi settlement in northern Uganda was established in August 2016 to provide refuge to people fleeing deadly fighting in South Sudan.

UGANDA | A welcoming neighbour for refugees

Uganda became home to more than 700,000 refugees by the end of 2016, after renewed fighting in South Sudan brought a large refugee influx. Uganda was among the top refugee host countries in Africa in 2016 with an average daily arrival of about 3,500 people.

The large number of refugees put the humanitarian response capacity in Uganda under enormous strain. Critical gaps emerged in education, water, sanitation, hygiene, and protection.

Having opened its new refugee response programme at the end 2014 in West Nile, NRC was strategically positioned to provide education, food security and water, sanitation and hygiene in existing and new settlements during the year. NRC programmes were active in Adjumani, Arua and Yumbe districts.

Food security and livelihoods

NRC supported displaced communities to attain food security and resilience by supporting small-scale businesses through cash transfers, supporting agro-based interventions and livelihood training. Cash grants enabled vulnerable youth to form groups and receive cash with an opportunity to generate income. More than 1,000 people received cash grants, and were able to establish small-scale enterprises.

Over 4,200 people benefited from emergency household items such as watering cans and saucepans.

NRC used its vocational skills training centres for civic engagement activities as well as training in numeracy, literacy, protection and life skills. NRC reached over 1,300 youth with these activities in 2016.

Water, sanitation and hygiene

NRC provided clean water by drilling and rehabilitating 19 boreholes, installing 19 water storage tanks, trucking water distribution services, laying water pipes, motorising boreholes and constructing water taps. Safe drinking water was obtained by providing jerry cans, water quality testing and water purification tablets.

NRC also conducted sanitation and hygiene activities in schools and refugee settlements. The activities included distribution of hygiene and promotional kits, hygiene and sanitation promotional campaigns, radio talk shows, health education sessions, distribution of household latrine materials and the installation of handwashing facilities to displaced populations living in Yumbe, Arua and Adjumani settlements. NRC reached an estimated 70,000 people through these activities.

Education

NRC provided children and youth with primary education support, vocational skills training and the accelerated learning programme. Under primary education support, NRC improved on the quality of education in six primary schools.

This was achieved by providing furniture and educational materials to over 1700 pupils.

Youth vocational skills training was a key component of NRC's education work, aimed at generating income. In June 2016, some 500 students graduated and received start-up kits and tools. A second group of over 600 students enrolled, and expect to graduate soon.

NRC's response to emergencies continued to expand through the establishment of new centres in Maaji III, Eden and Wanyange primary schools. About 1600 pupils enrolled in all our accelerated learning centres. Additional classrooms and latrines were constructed, Q-desks and tents supplied, teachers recruited and educational materials distributed to these centres.

“Contrary to common belief, most refugees are not fleeing to Europe. The reality is that more refugees sought safety in Uganda per day at the end of 2016, than many wealthy European countries received the entire year” – NRC Secretary General Jan Egeland



Photo: NRC/Tiri Sørstein

“WE NO LONGER HEAR THE SOUND OF GUN-SHOTS”



Photo: NRC/Tini Skarstein

“It is good to be in Uganda,” says Mary Kiden. She fled from South Sudan last October, together with her brother and sisters. They now live in Bidibidi refugee settlement in Uganda.

Uganda welcomed more refugees last year than the total number of refugees and migrants crossing the Mediterranean into Europe.

Some 489,000 South Sudanese refugees fled to Uganda in 2016. In addition, a large number of refugees arrived from DR Congo and Burundi. In comparison, 362,000 people crossed the Mediterranean into Europe in the same period.

“Contrary to common belief, most refugees are not fleeing to Europe. The reality is that more refugees sought safety in Uganda per day at the end of 2016, than many wealthy European countries received the entire year,” said NRC’s Secretary General Jan Egeland.

In 2016, the refugee settlement Bidibidi in northern Uganda was among the world’s largest refugee settlements. It housed over 270,000 South Sudanese, about equal to the population of Newcastle in the United Kingdom.

The refugees praised the way the country has welcomed them: “It is good to be in Uganda. They allocated us a piece of land, we have free access to medical services and we feel safe. People died from gunshots in South Sudan. It made me afraid. Here we no longer need to listen to the sound of the guns,” said Mary Kiden (17), who fled South Sudan in 2015.